

Reflective Assessment: Decision Making and Problem Solving

Decision Making: Choosing Between Two Job Opportunities

In 2023, following the closure of the Amazon warehouse where I worked, I needed to find a new job and found myself considering two very different opportunities: a trainee dental nurse position and a contact centre adviser role at Butlin's. Choosing between them was difficult because each offered different advantages, while I was also uncertain about the career direction I wanted to pursue.

Dental nursing appealed to me because it offered the opportunity to learn something new and work towards a professional qualification, despite having no previous experience in the field. I felt that I had performed particularly well during the interview, which made the position seem like an opportunity I should not miss. My parents also encouraged me because they viewed the medical field positively and hoped I might develop an interest in it. However, I was uncomfortable around blood and the salary was relatively low, while accepting the position would also have meant funding my own training and paying additional transport costs because I did not drive.

In comparison, Butlin's offered higher pay, potential commission and an initial arrangement that allowed me to work from home three days per week. The working hours also appeared more manageable, although the role came with different concerns, particularly back to back calls, customer complaints and performance targets. I had never felt comfortable speaking on the telephone and, as English is not my first language, I was worried at the time about understanding different UK accents. After considering both opportunities, I eventually chose Butlin's because its financial advantages, hybrid arrangement and working hours outweighed the longer-term career opportunities I associated with dental nursing.

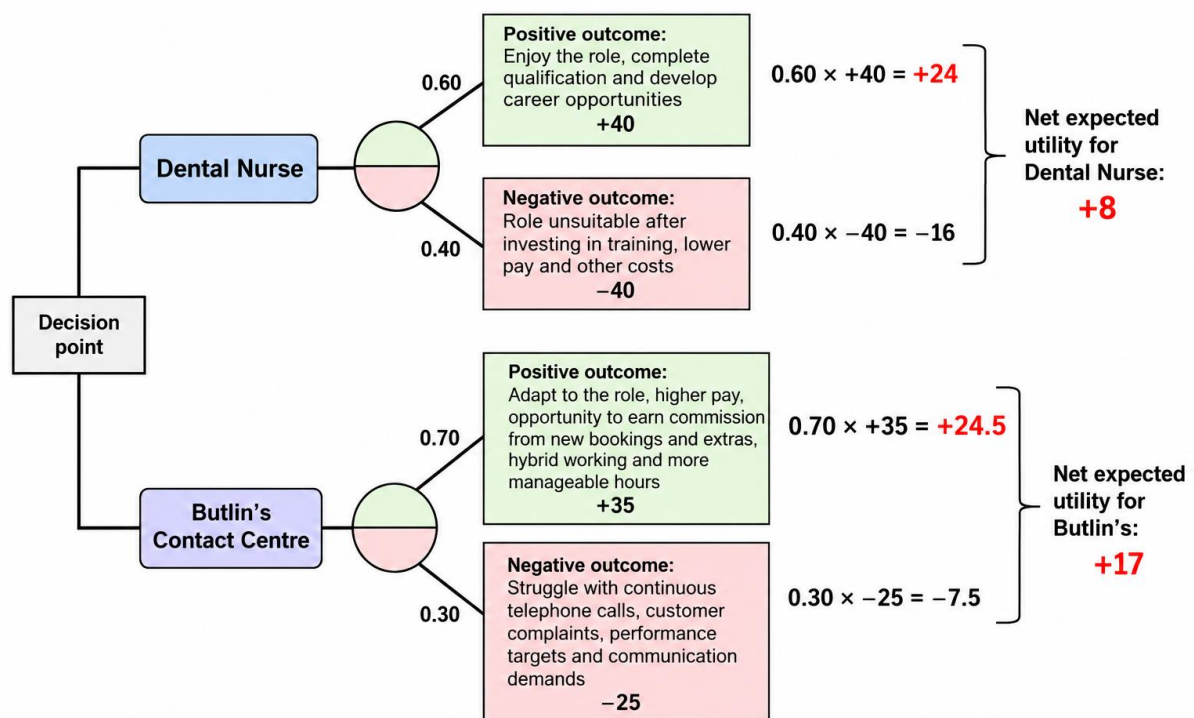
Reconsidering the Decision Using Expected Utility Theory

If I could return to the point at which I made this decision, I would approach the two opportunities more systematically using Expected Utility Theory (EUT), which has foundations in the work of von Neumann and Morgenstern (1944). Rather than considering the advantages and disadvantages mainly in my head, EUT would allow me to compare possible outcomes according to their probability and subjective value, or utility (Halpern & Dunn, 2023). This would have been particularly useful because both opportunities offered potential benefits but also involved uncertainties that I could not resolve before starting the job.

Applying EUT, I would assign dental nursing a 60% probability of a positive outcome with a utility of +40, representing successful adaptation to the clinical environment, completing the qualification and gaining longer-term career opportunities. The alternative negative outcome would have a 40% probability and utility of -40, reflecting the lower salary, training and travel costs and the possibility that the profession would not suit me. For Butlin's, I would estimate a 70% probability of a positive outcome with a utility of +35, reflecting higher pay,

potential commission and hybrid working, compared with a 30% probability of a negative outcome with a utility of -25 , representing difficult calls, targets and communication demands. As shown in Figure 1, this produces an expected utility of $+8$ for dental nursing and $+17$ for Butlin's, meaning that EUT would favour the same option I originally chose. However, I assigned dental nursing the higher positive utility because gaining a professional qualification potentially offered greater long-term career value.

Figure 1
Expected Utility Decision Tree



Reflection

Although EUT leads to the same choice, approaching the decision in this way would have made my reasoning more structured by requiring me to consider both the value and uncertainty of the possible outcomes. However, a higher expected utility does not demonstrate that Butlin's was objectively the better choice, as the probabilities were subjective estimates and the utilities reflected the personal value I placed on each outcome. This is an important limitation because expected utility approaches become less straightforward when probabilities cannot be objectively established (Gilboa, 2025).

The decision was also more complex than the numerical comparison suggests because my evaluation of both opportunities involved emotional responses. I was uncomfortable about encountering blood in dental nursing, whereas Butlin's created different concerns about telephone communication, understanding accents and dealing with difficult customers. As emotions can influence judgement and choice (Lerner et al., 2015), these concerns were

relevant to how I evaluated each opportunity. Although EUT could have helped me consider them alongside financial and career-related factors, it may not fully capture the emotional complexity involved in a personal decision.

This distinction is also important when considering what happened afterwards. Some aspects of Butlin's changed, including increased office attendance, while demanding calls and performance targets remained challenging; however, the role also improved my confidence when speaking on the telephone. These outcomes were not known when I made the original decision and should therefore not be used retrospectively to determine whether it was reasonable. Overall, although EUT would have led me to the same option, it could have produced a better-informed decision by making the reasoning behind my choice more systematic and transparent. It would not have guaranteed a better outcome, but it would have given me a clearer basis for making the decision under uncertainty.

Problem-Solving: Managing Work, University and Learning to Drive

In October 2024, I started taking driving lessons because gaining my driving licence had become an important personal goal that I wanted to achieve as soon as possible. I wanted greater independence and no longer wanted to rely on public transport or expensive Uber journeys, even for everyday activities such as grocery shopping. I was also aware that driving lessons were becoming increasingly expensive, which made postponing the process less appealing. However, achieving this goal became difficult because I was already working full time, studying at university and managing the responsibilities of living alone.

My driving lessons lasted two hours and usually took place two or three times per week, with each two hour lesson costing £70. Managing these commitments became particularly difficult when my working hours increased and I began working from 9 a.m. until 7 p.m. in the office. After spending a long day communicating with customers, I would sometimes still need to concentrate during a driving lesson or complete university work. I studied approximately four evenings per week and frequently used my breaks at work to study, while responsibilities such as preparing meals and managing my home also had to fit around this schedule. To manage these competing demands, I created a weekly calendar containing my work, driving lessons and university study and tried to follow it consistently. Although this helped me remain organised, my main approach was to fit everything into the limited time available. I stopped going to the gym and spent less time with family and friends, while sometimes sacrificing sleep to keep up with everything. I became increasingly overwhelmed and found concentrating particularly difficult after long working days, but I remained determined and eventually passed my driving test in June 2025.

Reconsidering the Problem Using a Structured Problem-Solving Approach

If I could return to the beginning of this situation, I would first define the problem more clearly using the concept of a problem space. Newell and Simon (1972) conceptualised problem solving as moving from an initial state towards a desired goal state through possible actions,

while Anderson (1993) later discussed and extended aspects of this framework, including Newell and Simon's account of means–ends problem solving. My initial state was therefore not simply being without a driving licence, but it also involved working long hours, studying, living independently and having limited time, energy and money. My desired state would be obtaining my licence while keeping these other responsibilities manageable.

From this clearer representation, I would use means–ends analysis to identify smaller steps that could reduce the difference between my current and desired states. Halpern and Dunn (2023) discuss strategies including clarifying goals, using external representations, creating subgoals and working backwards. Applied to my situation, my subgoals would include improving my driving skills, preparing for the practical test, meeting university deadlines, maintaining my performance at work and protecting sufficient time for sleep and essential responsibilities. I would therefore keep my weekly calendar as an external representation but use it more flexibly by planning backwards from university deadlines and the driving test rather than trying to fit as much as possible into every week.

This approach would also require recognising that I was pursuing several goals that competed for the same limited resources. Kung and Scholer (2020) identify choosing, multitasking and prioritising as strategies for managing conflict between multiple goals, while Alister et al. (2024) found that limited deliberation time and cognitive load can influence how people prioritise competing goals. This is particularly relevant because, after working until 7 p.m., my remaining time and mental resources were limited. Rather than repeatedly compensating by sacrificing sleep and personal time, I could have adjusted my priorities according to each week, reducing driving lessons around important university deadlines and increasing practice when my academic workload was lighter.

Reflection

Although my original approach was successful, passing my driving test does not necessarily mean that the process was the most manageable or sustainable. My calendar provided structure, but I often solved the lack of available time by sacrificing sleep, exercise and social activities. A more structured approach could have helped me consider not only how quickly I wanted to obtain my licence, but also how my limited time and energy should be distributed between several important goals.

However, these strategies would not have removed the underlying constraints. Reducing lessons during demanding university periods might have protected my sleep and concentration, but it could also have prolonged the learning process and increased its overall cost, conflicting with my aim of gaining my licence quickly while lesson prices were increasing. My working hours and university deadlines could not simply be removed either. Therefore, the main benefit of a more informed approach would not have been finding a perfect solution but making these trade-offs more deliberate and flexible. I may ultimately have reached the same outcome, but potentially through a process that placed less pressure on my wellbeing and other responsibilities.

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